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APPLIED LINGUISTICS

Prepared by Karen L. Smith*

Language Maintenance and Ethnic Survival: The Portuguese in New Jersey

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0. Introduction.[1]

The history of ethnic Portuguese in America spans approximately 170 years from the earliest certifiable immigrants in the 1820s. Portuguese immigration to the United States became relatively heavy in the 1830s, which marked the beginning of steady Lusitanian, specifically Azorean, arrivals. These immigrants at first congregated in the fishing areas of New England, centering around New Bedford, Massachusetts. Later, in the 1850s, Portuguese farmers and fishermen began migrations to California, especially the San Francisco area. The first Portuguese parish in the United States, St. John the Baptist in New Bedford, was founded in 1869 (Rogers 1980: 816). We know, however, that the Portuguese constituted a significant and stable ethnic community in America by 1860, when the first Portuguese-speaking Roman Catholic priests arrived in the United States.

From the late nineteenth through the mid twentieth century, major influxes of Portuguese settled into the states of California, Massachusetts, New York, and New Jersey, starting communities and commercial ventures in each. New federal immigration laws of the early 1970s, however, stemmed Portuguese arrivals in the United States for about three years. Nonetheless, the tide turned upward again in 1974, when about 12,000 Portuguese settlers came to the United States (Keefe 1977: 96). With such relatively heavy migrations, one might expect that the Portuguese language has been well-preserved in the new social environment. This paper will examine the scope of Portuguese language maintenance and ethnicity in and around Newark, New Jersey. An analysis of the social and linguistic situations will show how one relatively homogeneous immigrant group responds to external stimuli with regard to language, culture, and ethnicity.

1. The Portuguese in America.

The Portuguese-Americans continue in the mold of the classic, ever-suffering immigrant group, victims of prejudices generated by ignorance and reinforced by both the high illiteracy rate of the early settlers and their concomitant dearth of technical labor skills (Wittke 1939: 11). Whereas many early immigrants were illiterate in Portuguese, their lack of English language skills and reluctance or inability to learn it immediately further intensified their problems in the Anglo-American environment (Taft 1969: 160). Clearly, this situation fomented the continuation of Portuguese language use among the early Portuguese immigrants.

Spawning further out-migrations, crop failures in nineteenth-century Portugal had forced many Portuguese to seek refuge and jobs elsewhere; America, both North and South, was the answer for most emigres (Taft 1969: 63). They sought the mythically high salaries of the American worker, but were often overwhelmed with the reality of low wages for the untrained. The search for a better life eluded many of them, as a direct result of their linguistic and technical deficiencies. To exacerbate the emotional problems of these people, there was also a very high

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infant mortality rate, as Taft (1969: 151) has recorded. All of these elements combined to present Portuguese-Americans with a very difficult life in their adopted land; none of these factors alone, however, was powerful enough to stem the flow from Portuguese territories.

1.2. Portuguese Institutions and Efforts of Language Maintenance.

According to the 1980 Census of the United States, persons of Portuguese descent numbers 1,075,206 for the entire country. That figure does not necessarily account for the number of persons who use Portuguese in their everyday life, nor does it consider separately those of Luso-Brazilian descent.

The extent to which Portuguese-Americans have assimilated to the Anglo-American culture and English language is most often determined by the four basic factors of education, religion, mass media, and cultural organizations (Saraiva and do Carmo 1978: 22). In many Portuguese communities, bilingual or Portuguese monolingual church masses, multilingual media, and cultural groups usually in the form of social clubs, shepherd Portuguese language and culture maintenance. Even some bilingual education programs serve to reinforce the Portuguese language while teaching only rudimentary English. Nonetheless, the degree of acquisition of English and of assimilation to American culture is reflected in and determined by these four elements.

Knowledge of English, a survival skill in the general Anglo-American environment, has escaped many Portuguese-Americans. Their native language often remains the lifeline to Old World culture and traditions. Within the expatriate community, Portuguese still obtains as a tool of survival; even non-Portuguese use Portuguese words and expressions in their daily contacts with members of the Portuguese community (Middleton 1986: 7). In fact, Pap (1949: 20) has indicated that, in the 1940s, second-generation Portuguese-Americans still spoke mostly Portuguese, a pattern typical even today.

The Portuguese and many other minority groups have confronted many obstacles in their efforts to maintain their language and/or culture in the United States, most specifically language shift toward the use of English. Nevertheless, the Portuguese have formed schools to teach or reinforce native language skills and cultural awareness. Many churches have encouraged festivals (e.g., the Festa do Espírito Santo, an Azorean festival shared by all Portuguese). The Catholic Church has cushioned some of the shock for immigrants, serving as a haven for the newly-arrived. Moreover, the Church has encouraged strong morality and group identity, both of which characterize the Portuguese communities of America.

The print and broadcast media have been an important element in Portuguese language maintenance and group identity in the United States. Portuguese journals have flourished and are found today in most Portuguese-speaking households (Cortes 1980: 31-32). These periodicals have not only helped to educate the Portuguese citizens but also to sustain links with events in their native lands. Furthermore, Portuguese-language radio and television programs can be found in any area of the United States in which a large concentration of Portuguese immigrants resides.

Social organizations, especially private clubs, have required, however unconsciously, native language use among the Portuguese who have become members. These clubs are generally restrictive in their membership; that is to say, they admit members depending on their place of origin in the Portuguese-speaking world, Azorean clubs for Azoreans, Madeiran clubs for Madeirans, and so on. On one hand, these organizations have not only preserved various Portuguese language varieties but have also retained regional cultural traditions. On the other hand, this division could also foreshadow the fortune of preservation efforts with regard to the Portuguese language in America.

The origins of this divisiveness hark back to earlier events, specifically to the social situation of Portugal and its colonial territories. Azoreans in particular have been perennially derided for their low-class social standing in comparison to Continental Portuguese or Madeirans.[2] The Azorean variety of Portuguese has thus suffered the stigma of inferiority, a patois of the worst sort (Middleton 1986: 21). The social scale prevalent outside America has therefore decided language acceptability and has isolated a segment of an already isolated population in America. Even with this fragmentation, these people continue to express pride in themselves, their society and culture, and their language (Middleton 1986: 7). Of utmost importance, however, is that

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Portuguese-Americans want to retain links with their history while trying to achieve prosperity in a new social and economic environment.

2. Newark's Portuguese-Americans: Language and Culture Survival.

Newark, New Jersey, famous for its ethnic diversity, is presently home to about 65,000 Portuguese speakers.[3] The Portuguese community of Newark is concentrated in the section known as the "Ironbound," a self-contained and somewhat physically isolated blue-collar area, a stronghold of Cubans, Puerto Ricans, Galicians, Portuguese, Hungarians, Italians, Slavs, and other ethnic groups for over 100 years. Spanish, Italian, and Portuguese are commonly heard on the streets of the Ironbound (*Clarion* n.d.: 1). Monroe Street, once known as the "Portuguese Broadway," is the point of origin of the Ironbound Portuguese community.

The Portuguese-Americans of Newark are regarded as a hardworking and vital element of the society in that they have high visibility and uphold their excellent reputation. They began arriving in large groups in the 1920s (Cunha 1981: 34). According to Carpenter (1979: 61), the Portuguese settlement in Newark's Ironbound "was the most thorough colonization in the ethnic history of New Jersey." Newark's Portuguese community is a microcosm of ethnic life and minority culture in the United States.

2.1. The Impact of Education on Portuguese Language and Culture.

The basic elements common to other cultural communities in the country, including other Portuguese areas of concentration, are also found in Newark. The Newark Portuguese community has taken advantage of knowing English in order to advance in the workplace; the Portuguese are in fact quite in favor of learning English. Portuguese-English bilingual programs have been established not only in Newark but also in other New Jersey communities such as nearby Elizabeth, South River, and Harrison (Saraiva and do Carmo 1978: 22; Ferreira n.d.: 6). Even though these bilingual programs have often reinforced Portuguese while teaching very little English, as has been the case with other bilingual programs in the United States, they demonstrate the efforts of the Portuguese people to walk the tightrope between a minority culture and assimilation into Anglo-American society.

In an effort to thwart further erosion of their language and culture, the Portuguese communities of New Jersey have established about 15 private Portuguese schools, similar to the more well-known Hebrew schools and other correlate minority language and culture schools. Some of these schools offer after-school programs, others give Saturday school classes, and a few are accredited schools in which Portuguese is the language of instruction.

The language notwithstanding, the Portuguese people show a great propensity toward Americanization. Obviously the Portuguese have never benefited from a well-developed Portuguese-language infrastructure (Sayers 1968: 75). That is, there have been few social demands for use of Portuguese in the American environment, and few English speakers study Portuguese in the classroom. According to figures released by the Ministry of Education of Portugal for the year 1977, only about 5,500 persons in the United States studied basic or intermediate Portuguese, statistics which indicate the American attitude toward the importance of the Portuguese language in American life.

2.2. The Impact of the Church on Portuguese Language Survival.

Of the four basic institutions instrumental in language preservation, the Catholic Church has had a major influence on Portuguese-Americans. The largest Portuguese church in New Jersey, Our Lady of Fatima in Elizabeth, boasts over 15,000 Portuguese-speaking parishioners, even though it was founded only in 1973. That church holds mass in Portuguese and sponsors a cultural center, a day-care center, and various other social programs. The parish also publishes a newsletter-type paper, *Novos Rumos,* in Portuguese. Other non-Portuguese churches in the Newark area hold some masses in Portuguese, indicating that the Portuguese community has already expanded beyond the traditional limits of the Ironbound.

2.3. The Impact of the Print and Broadcast Media on Portuguese.

Several Portuguese-language newspapers flourish in Newark and its environs. Among

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them, the largest circulation belongs to the *Luso-Americano,* with 15,000 subscribers. Established in 1928 and published regularly from 1939, it is also the oldest Portuguese publication still in existence in New Jersey today. Besides the *Luso-Americano,* two other Portuguese-language newspapers, the *Portuguese News,* established in 1978, and the *Portuguese Times,* founded in Newark in 1971, serve the Portuguese-speaking community in New Jersey and elsewhere in the United States.

Factos e Gente (a somewhat anglicized title loosely translated as "Facts and People") is a news-and-views format magazine with an upbeat approach to journalism that also caters to the Newark-area Portuguese population (Middleton 1986: 27). This journal handles news from around the world and employs a staff of both national and international correspondents who concentrate reporting efforts on Portugal and topics related to that country. This magazine gives the Portuguese speakers a handy knowledge of subjects relevant to them, even though these items do not necessarily impinge on their everyday lives.

The Newark-Linden based multilingual television station WNJU, channel 47, presents a daily "Hora Portuguesa," with variety entertainment and news reports. The Portuguese Broadcasting Company, a cable television station established in 1983, broadcasts international and local news and information from both Portugal and Brazil to the Newark and Elizabeth audiences. Several local radio stations broadcast daily programs in Portuguese, offering music, news, and information to the Portuguese community.

2.4. The Impact of Social Organizations on Portuguese.

Social clubs also reflect the lifestyle and customs of the Newark Portuguese community. These clubs have promoted Portuguese language maintenance either directly or indirectly since 1928, when the first, the "Sport Clube Português," was founded in Newark (Middleton 1986: 28). Presently there are at least four very active social clubs in Newark, Elizabeth, Lodi, and South River, each offering a variety of athletics, educational opportunities, and entertainment.

An event that affected the social life, ethnic composition, and linguistic situation of the Ironbound was the gradual exodus of the Italians in the late 1960s as a result of Newark's racial riots and the resultant redefinition of ethnic communities, often along racial lines. As the Italians left, more Portuguese moved in, bringing more institutions and traditions. According to Middleton (1986: 30), about 40% of all private housing in the Ironbound at present belongs to someone of Portuguese descent. This situation indicates that the Ironbound has become more than simply an island of Portuguese ethnicity and linguistic hegemony, and that the Portuguese have gained in economic stature as well.

3. Summary.

The impact of Anglo-American society and contacts with other cultures indicate how well Portuguese language and culture will endure in its present milieu. In some instances, clannishness amongst the Portuguese has led to self-isolation and monolingualism in Portuguese. With the need to use English in most affairs outside the community, many Portuguese have been unable to escape the cycle of the unskilled labor force until quite recently.

Edwards (1985: 72) has indicated that the media can both aid language maintenance and hurry language shift through the addition of non-native elements. This seemingly facile argument can be made for any minority language group outside its original area. It does not necessarily follow, however, that the increase in foreign elements in a language will foment language death in that group. On the other hand, Edwards's suggestion of a tendency toward international cultural leveling as a result of media bombardment does bear weight in the argument for shift; language, being the most obvious marker of culture, cannot often survive the impetus of an overwhelming international culture and language. Such may be the case with the Portuguese in Newark and the United States in general.

The desire of native Portuguese people to return to Portugal is one of the main reasons for maintaining the Portuguese language and culture in America (Middleton 1986: 7-8). Many Portuguese pensioners or retirees fully expect to return to Portugal one day in order to enjoy the relative wealth afforded them in their homeland. Nonetheless, according to the 25 December 1985 issue of the *Luso-Americano,* over 1,100 persons of Portuguese descent became American citizens during that month alone; this affirmation of permanence

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and allegiance indicates that the trend toward back-migration may now have been slowed if not reversed.

Portuguese-Americans have shown no tendency to reject their heritage while in the United States. Nonetheless, many factors of daily life in America foster loss of cultural identity within the community. Some scholars, nonetheless, believe that cultural "identity survives language loss" (Edwards 1985: 66-67). In the 1980s the Ironbound Portuguese residents have begun to disperse to other cities of northern New Jersey, including North Newark, South River, Kearny, Harrison, and North Arlington. With this out-migration from a concentrated and self-contained *bairro,* the fate of the Portuguese language would seem to be sealed. Geographical distance between Portuguese speakers in America and a lack of psychological ties with Portugal may prove fatal to the Portuguese language maintenance efforts in the United States. The concomitant loss of Portuguese ethnic identity in the Newark community, however, does not appear to be imminent.

NOTES

[1]An earlier version of this paper was presented at the Fifth Annual Meeting of the Southeast Conference on Foreign Languages and Literatures, Rollins College, Winter Park, FL, February 1987.

[2]The problem is made more acute by the intervention of traditional racial factors, especially skin color or other phenotypic traits. The fact that many Azoreans and Cape Verdeans are dark-skinned, or Black by the American definition, has affected the social standing of these groups within Portuguese societies, both on the European continent and elsewhere.

[3]See Ferreira n.d.: 1. Cabral (1983), however, states that the Portuguese-Americans number about 20,000 in Newark and 40,000 in New Jersey. The 65,000 noted by Ferreira is a better approximation, since it is both more recent, more unintrusive, and thus less forbidding to those reluctant to be counted, than an official census.

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